7 Applying to Your First Conference and Writing an Abstract

Once you have a research agenda, the next step in your professional development is to begin attending academic conferences. Ideally, you will begin submitting conference applications toward the end of your proposal-writing process and present your review and problematization of the literature at a conference soon after you have defended your proposal. Other presentations will follow as your research progresses.

Conference presentations exemplify the potential synergies between dissertation completion and professional development. Presenting at conferences will allow you to collect feedback on your work from people besides your dissertation advisor or committee, expose you to new ideas that may be relevant to your research, and give you opportunities to develop your professional network. Conference papers are also important signifiers of professional ability, and once you have written and received feedback on a conference paper you can usually turn it into an article with a modicum of additional effort.

Note that in all of this, we are focusing on presenting at conferences, not merely attending them. There is no section in most CVs for conferences attended. Listening to others present their work can be highly beneficial, but it does not reflect a unique accomplishment. Students who merely attend a conference may find themselves on the periphery of the conference community, without a clear path for breaking into the "scholarly huddle" (Chapman et al. 2009; cf. Kim, Lebovits, and Shugars 2021). In contrast, presenting a paper signals your membership in the scholarly

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community and creates bridges for launching conversations and building your network. Given the limitations of time and funding that most PhD students face, I discourage students from attending conferences unless they are also presenting. Applying to present may seem daunting at first, but there are many conferences each year, ranging from huge international affairs to small, specialist workshops. Using the guidance in this chapter, you should be able to find a conference that suits you and will accept your proposal.

In this chapter, we will discuss in more detail why you should attend conferences and what you will get out of attending them. We will then examine what research outputs are suitable for conference submission and when you should expect to present them. Next, we will explore the types of conferences available and how to pick an appropriate one. Finally, we will discuss how to write a successful abstract, which will form the core of your conference proposal.

Why You Should Attend Conferences

On their face, conferences may seem like extra, unnecessary work and expense, especially if you do not intend to pursue an academic career. Conferences can also seem intimidating – places where you risk being publicly critiqued by more senior scholars or where your best ideas may be stolen. For these reasons, you may meet fellow students who do not go to conferences at all. However, this is short-sighted. Conferences are an excellent place to receive feedback on your work, stay abreast of the latest developments in the field, and network with other scholars. Conference attendance can also help build your CV, form a springboard to article publication, provide inspiration, and help you overcome your fears. This section will discuss these benefits. (The next chapter, on participating in and presenting at conferences, will give you guidance on dealing with critical audience members and protecting your intellectual property.)

First and most importantly, conferences are opportunities for you to receive feedback on your work (Gupta and Waismel-Manor 2006). Our research builds on the work of our colleagues and predecessors in the field. The volume of this previous research is often so vast that it is difficult to master it all. Critiques from others help clue us in to what we have missed. Other scholars can also offer suggestions based on their own experience, research, and perspectives, helping us consider our research from new angles. If you study the

acknowledgments section of articles in the top journals in your field, you will often find that these pieces thank numerous other scholars for their input. Good feedback makes for better research.

By presenting your work at a conference, you invite this feedback. Most conferences require you to submit a conference paper, usually the length of a typical academic article in your field, a few weeks before you present. Some conferences will feature a dedicated discussant as part of each panel, whose job it is to read and critique the papers and, ideally, identify links among them. Fellow panelists will also read (or at least skim) your work and offer helpful questions or comments. Most audience members are unlikely to read your work in advance, but they will listen to your presentation and respond with questions and comments as well. Often interested audience members will approach you after you present to request a copy of your paper. You can ask these new contacts to send you any feedback they have once they have read it. Not all this input will seem appropriate or accurate, but even where the feedback reflects a misunderstanding of your work, it can help you identify things you need to explain more clearly or discuss in more detail.

In addition to presenting your own work, you will listen to others present theirs (Cooper 2008). Other scholars will also be presenting their new research for feedback prior to submitting it for publication. By attending panels related to your research, you can hear about the latest developments in the field, learn about theories or sources you may have overlooked, and even meet some of the leading lights in your domain of research (Bassey n.d.).

As you present and as you listen, you will have opportunities to build your network (Mata, Latham, and Ransome 2010; Cooper 2008). Often the members of your panel will meet for drinks or a meal to discuss their work. Audience members will approach you after you present and, sometimes, discuss ways your work relates to their own projects. When you are an audience member you can do likewise, approaching the presenters of pieces that interest you. These connections can be invaluable for building your career (Gupta and Waismel-Manor 2006). One of my grad school presentations garnered an invitation to participate in an edited volume and, later, to apply for a postdoc. Conference interactions with a fellow grad student eventually led to us coauthoring two articles together. Now, as a more senior scholar, I have invited graduate students I have met at conferences to submit work for a special issue of a journal or a volume I was editing or sent them advertisements for jobs at my institution.

PAPER OR POSTER?

Many conferences offer the option of presenting a poster instead of a paper. At a poster session, a dozen or more scholars (usually graduate students) stand in a gallery next to posters visualizing their research. Audience members wander through and stop to talk with researchers whose work interests them. Posters can be an effective means of information transfer (Rowe and Ilic 2009). However, a poster presentation lacks the guarantee of feedback you get from being on a panel. The format is also less readily converted into a publication, and a poster presentation often has less cachet than a paper. Given that preparing a poster is just as much work as preparing a paper, I always suggest that students present a paper if they have the option to do so.

Conference presentations are listed on your CV and show that you are an active scholar. As noted in Chapter 3, presenting at conferences recognized by your future employer can help mark you as an insider in the profession. This is true even for non-academic jobs.

Ideally, every conference paper can be developed into a publication. Once you have written a paper and received feedback, revising and submitting the paper for publication can take as little as two or three days of additional effort. Indeed, be careful about attending too many conferences without converting your papers into publications; this can send the wrong signal on your CV, making you look like someone who goes to conferences for vacation rather than a serious scholar (Haggerty 2010).

Conferences provide inspiration (Bassey n.d.). There is something about being surrounded by fellow researchers and hearing lots of new ideas that is exciting. As my time at a conference progresses, I find myself filled with new ideas – research opportunities to explore, grants to investigate, new contacts to follow up with, and ways to improve my own work. If you are feeling stalled or unmotivated, a conference may be just the thing to revive your momentum. The commitment to produce a paper by the conference deadline can also provide the pressure many of us need to get a difficult project done.

Lastly, going to conferences can help you overcome your fears and build your confidence (Gupta and Waismel-Manor 2006). You will gain confidence in your ability to make presentations and speak publicly about your research (Simpson n.d.). You may also begin to recognize the interests and traits you share with other

career researchers, helping you to see yourself as one of the group and perhaps helping you overcome the imposter syndrome that plagues many early-career researchers (Bassey n.d.). Your first conference may feel challenging, but once you have some experience, conferences will become more comfortable environments and more professionally fruitful (Chapman et al. 2009).

What to Present and When

If these arguments have persuaded you that you should present at conferences, you will need to know what to present and when to begin applying. You may also be wondering about where you should apply. We will discuss this question later; you need to reflect on what you are presenting before seeking a suitable venue.

You should consider the questions of what to present and when to apply in the context of the timeline you have constructed for your dissertation. Major conferences often have a lead time of nine or more months, meaning that you must submit a proposal nine or more months before you expect to present your work. Smaller conferences and workshops may have shorter lead times, perhaps three to six months, but these times are still significant. No one, especially a PhD student eager to get feedback and proceed with their dissertation, wants to let completed work sit for months while waiting for a chance to present it and receive feedback. As a result, most scholars submit conference proposals long before the work they intend to present is complete. You should do this too. Begin submitting conference proposals as soon as you know what you *intend* to research or write, even if this work has barely begun. If your proposal is accepted, the conference then gains an additional function, alluded to above: a commitment device (Haggerty 2010). As you will no doubt discover, there will be many days during the dissertation process when your motivation will lag and your work will slow. (We'll discuss how to manage your time and motivation in Chapter 12.) Knowing that you will need to present and defend your work in front of a live audience can help you push through the block.

I suggest that students begin submitting conference proposals when they have a second or third draft of their dissertation proposal complete. You do not need to have defended your dissertation proposal, but you need to be deep enough into the literature and preliminary data to know that your question is novel and meaningful, and you need to have had enough meetings with your advisor for you to know that your planned work is unlikely to radically change. Because the key to good professional development during the PhD process is maximizing synergies between the dissertation-writing process and your professional development, you

do not want to be committed to writing and presenting a conference paper that is no longer directly connected to your dissertation.

Your first conference paper should be based on your dissertation proposal. A good proposal will review the research, problematize it, and propose a theoretical framework and research plan that will address that problematization. The first three of these elements – a literature review, problematization, and new theoretical framework – are the backbone of what is known as a review article or review piece. Not to be confused with a book review (which examines the pros and cons of a single volume), a review piece aims to capture the current state of research in a field, provides a framework that helps organize the ongoing scholarly discussion, and leverages this framework to pinpoint ways that the field needs to move forward, e.g., by highlighting latent debates, areas of imprecision, or unanswered questions (Paul and Criado 2020; Webster and Watson 2002). Your first conference paper should distill your proposal into a review piece. If you talk to your professors or skim through some journals in your field, you will find plenty of examples of this sort of publication that can serve as a template for your work.

Presenting a revised and abridged version of your proposal as a conference paper will give you feedback on your review of the literature and your theoretical framework. This is useful because most of the material from your proposal will appear again in your dissertation. You may add to it or expand on it, but you will probably copy and paste whole sections of your review of the literature straight into your dissertation. Indeed, if you are writing a big book dissertation (as opposed to one composed of stand-alone articles) you will probably have a chapter dedicated just to reviewing the literature. Thus, even if you have already defended your proposal by the time of your conference presentation, the feedback you receive will still improve your dissertation. Moreover, you can use that feedback to refine your conference paper as you develop it into an article.

The process of submitting conference proposals should continue as you proceed with developing your dissertation. If your dissertation has specific sub-questions to answer, the answer to each question or set of questions will often be interesting enough for its own conference paper. The same is true if you are doing multiple case studies, testing several different sets of hypotheses, or examining two different sets of data as part of a mixed-methods approach. Such natural delineations in your work can help you identify pieces of the larger dissertation suitable for stand-alone conference papers and presentations.

When you begin data collection or begin building your statistical models, you should take the time to submit conference proposals timed so that the conference

dates will align with whenever you expect the data collection and analysis to be complete. The conference proposals will push you to convert your data or analyses into written outputs and help you to get feedback on your efforts to make sense of your data. If you think you will have multiple outputs, you can submit proposals to multiple conferences or even submit multiple papers to a single conference – many conferences allow two presentations. Just make sure to include the necessary writing time for the papers in your PhD timeline.

Lastly, as you near the end of your dissertation process and develop a completed first draft of your dissertation, you may want to submit conference proposals that distill your entire dissertation or highlight its key findings. While the review piece based on your proposal and other pieces based on your intermediate outputs may end up published in mid-tier journals, you should attempt to wring at least one really good, top-tier journal article out of your dissertation by publishing a piece that showcases your most robust and important insights. This journal article can start as a conference paper. Although you cannot yet know your findings, it may be useful to reflect on what might be the focus of that culminating paper, to help create a mental category or bucket that you can fill as your dissertation generates data and ideas.

EXERCISE 7.1: MATERIAL FOR CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Drawing on your research question exercises from Chapter 5:

1. Identify the focus or title of a potential review piece based on your dissertation proposal.
2. Brainstorm additional paper topics that may result from your data collection and analysis.
3. Reflect on the focus of your culminating paper. What questions will it answer for academics or practitioners?

Dangers and Solutions

There are some dangers in timing your conference submissions around your projected progress on the dissertation. One is that you will not complete the work you intend to do because of circumstances beyond your control. Maybe your visa does not come through for fieldwork or you cannot get access to the dataset you planned to use. Will you have to withdraw your paper? Will you be publicly shamed? This risk is less serious than it seems at first glance.

Assuming you are still writing your PhD and not giving up, you will find an alternative way forward – e.g., conducting interviews remotely or using a different dataset. Most conferences have a window a few months before the conference when you can revise the title and abstract you have submitted. You should use this window if there have been significant changes in your research plan. However, if your core research questions are unchanged, your paper should still fit with the panel to which you have been assigned and no one is likely to complain. Other scholars understand the challenges of research and they will respect the effort you have made to find a solution.

A second danger is that you will not complete the work because of circumstances you can control. For example, you did not work fast enough, or you did not buckle down and do the writing. My main advice is to not let this be you. Discussants sometimes call out panel members who have not submitted their papers on time, even if just to explain to the audience why the discussant is not prepared to discuss that panelist's work. Remember that the PhD is about the process of becoming credentialled as an independent scholar. Managing your time and finding a way to motivate yourself to get the work done can be a struggle, but it is one you will have to overcome to earn the degree. It can be done; we'll discuss strategies in Chapter 12.

A third danger is that you preview in your conference proposal conclusions that turn out to be unsupported by your data or analysis. After all, one of the problems with submitting a proposal in advance is that you are expected to summarize the results of research you have not actually done! The key thing to remember when this happens is to never try to massage your results to fit your earlier assumptions. This is anathema to good research. Instead, write your paper about the unexpected results of your research, even your null findings. Use the conference window for abstract and title revisions if you know your results early enough. Otherwise take some time at the beginning of your conference presentation to discuss your research process and its unexpected results. If you can explain why you unexpectedly got a null finding or an unforeseen finding, that itself may be interesting to the audience members. In any case, if you are addressing the same research question you discussed in your conference proposal, your findings will fit the panel and be valuable to those who attend.

Picking a Conference

Once you have an idea for your conference paper and presentation, the next step is to pick an appropriate conference. Finding options is fairly

straightforward. Conferences and workshops are typically advertised via calls for papers (or just "calls"), that describe the conference focus or theme and lay out the requirements and due dates for proposals. Make sure to read carefully; the phrase "call for papers" is also used to solicit materials for special issues of a journal or an edited volume.

There are a number of websites that aggregate conference calls and let you search among them. The major professional associations in your discipline or field may maintain a list of upcoming conferences. You can also ask your professors about any listservs in your field or subfield; many events – especially smaller workshops – are advertised through these. You should be able to locate some good options through an hour or two of web searches, complemented by conversations with your peers and professors.

EXERCISE 7.2: FINDING SOURCES FOR CALLS FOR PAPERS

1. Identify the major professional association in your discipline or subject area and note its next annual conference or meeting.
2. Identify one or more websites that aggregate calls for conference proposals in your discipline or subject area.
3. In consultation with your advisor or peers, identify and subscribe to one or more listservs or other feeds through which calls for conference papers are regularly advertised in your field.

The real challenge is choosing among the options you find. When you first begin looking at academic conferences, you may be overwhelmed by the number of choices available (Simpson n.d.). Imagine that you are studying at a university in Texas in the field of comparative political science with a dissertation focused on municipal elections in rural towns in Mexico. You find that you can submit a proposal to the Southwestern Political Science Association, the American Political Science Association, the International Studies Association, the Latin American Studies Association, a conference on rural development, or a workshop examining municipal elections across different countries and continents. How do you choose?

In selecting a conference, you should follow several principles. Most importantly, you will want to pick a conference where your paper fits well with the general focus of the conference, such as international studies or rural development. Doing so increases the likelihood that your work will be accepted, but even more importantly, it increases the likelihood that

your presentation will be seen by people who are qualified to comment on it and who will give you feedback that improves your work. Those same people will be valuable contacts, and watching their presentations will benefit your growth as a scholar. Second, you will want to pick at least some conferences with strong reputations. Small specialist gatherings can be very exciting because of the high degree of synergy among the participants' work, but you also want to have some events on your CV that future employers will recognize. Review the work you did in Chapter 2 and look for the conferences that are often attended by people holding the sorts of jobs you would like to have. Third, you will need to pick conferences you can afford to attend. If you want to present the same work more than once, these will also need to be conferences where the audiences are unlikely to overlap. Lastly, you will need to avoid scam conferences – high-priced gatherings organized by for-profit entities with little (or even negative) professional value.

REPEAT PRESENTATIONS

There are several legitimate ways to present the same material multiple times. One is to present it at events where the audiences are unlikely to significantly overlap (Dometrius 2008). For instance, you could present the work at a small, topical workshop and again at a big disciplinary event. Another is to present your findings in revised form if there is significant time (6–12 months) between the conferences (Copper 2008). Your work can improve and you can share with the audience how it has evolved. Lastly, you can combine data from an old paper with new data to address different research questions.

Unless your work has changed so much that it warrants a new title, do not change the title of your presentation. This allows prospective audience members scanning the conference program to avoid a repeat, and it creates a more honest CV.

Resist any temptation you may feel to inflate your CV by presenting the exact same paper multiple times under different titles, especially at conferences with overlapping audiences. Doing so is considered bad form and may irritate hiring committees (Dometrius 2008). Moreover, when the members of your audience come to hear you, they forego the chance to hear someone else. If they come and hear the same paper you presented last time, you do them a disservice.

Rather than describing how to assess these factors afresh for every conference, it is useful to discuss how they align in the four types of conferences you will most typically encounter: disciplinary conferences, topical conferences, workshops and symposia, and scam conferences.

Disciplinary Conferences

One way of finding alignment between your work and the conference is to pick a large conference organized in a particular discipline. Whatever your discipline, there is almost certainly a professional group within your country or continent that hosts a regular gathering. The American Anthropological Association, the European Consortium for Political Research, and the American Sociological Association all host annual meetings. So do the South African Sociological Association and the Israeli Political Science Association. These events can be quite large: the European and American meetings often have thousands of participants.

Many of these conferences have a special theme for the gathering, usually related to current events or recent developments in the field. However, your work does not have to fit the conference theme. These conferences are gathering points for everyone in a certain profession or who shares a certain disciplinary perspective, and they are structured accordingly. Often members with a shared interest or sub-discipline will have a section that will organize a track that reviews relevant proposals and organizes the successful ones into panels. You can download conference programs from previous years to see the diversity of papers presented. For some conferences you will need to pick out which sections or tracks you would like to consider your conference proposal during the proposal submission process.

The virtue of these major conferences is that at least some of the attendees are likely to be interested in your research and the conference will be easily recognized on your CV, increasing its reputational value. If you are near the end of your PhD program and getting ready for the job market, you will also find that some employers conduct preliminary interviews at the major conference in your discipline or field. The challenge is that sometimes these conferences have so many panels that some of them are quite poorly attended. And while it is certain that some of the people attending the conference will be interested in your work, it is also certain that the majority attending will not. At a conference of 5000 people, there may only be 50 who are truly interested in your topic. This sharply reduces the odds that a spontaneous encounter in the queue at the coffee bar will yield an important contact.

Lastly, major conferences like these are often held in big cities with good airline connections. This can make travel to the conference cheaper but make accommodation more expensive.

The major disciplinary conferences in your field may be complemented by smaller local versions. For instance, in addition to the massive annual meeting of the American Political Science Association there is also a meeting of the Southern Political Science Association (serving states in the southern US) and of the Georgia Political Science Association (serving political scientists in the southern US state of Georgia). These conferences can represent an inexpensive, low-risk way to gain experience. A paper you present at a local conference can typically be repeated at a national or international one. However, unless you are interested in local or regional issues, the number of scholars whose interests overlap your own may be lower at these local conferences than at major national ones, limiting the quantity and quality of feedback you receive. Your networking will also be concentrated on colleagues in your region, which can be very helpful if you are looking for a local job but less useful for a wider search.

Topical Conferences

Other regular conferences exist among researchers interested in a particular topic. The International Health Economics Association meets biannually. In my own field of NGO research, the Association for Research on Nonprofit Organizations and Voluntary Action meets every year, usually in the US, while the International Society for Third-Sector Research meets biannually, usually in Europe.

In my experience, these more topical meetings involve more practitioners, which can be an important consideration if you plan a practitioner career. They are also sometimes smaller: maybe 600–1000 participants as opposed to 2000 or more at a major disciplinary conference. Often the panels are better attended (although this depends on the willingness of the organizers to not over-schedule) and the audience is more likely to be expert in your topic and interested in engaging in discussion. The number of people truly interested in your research will increase and the odds of meeting them spontaneously improves even more if the total number of participants is smaller. Over time, I have come to prefer these topical conferences as better venues for getting feedback and doing networking. The downside is that they may have less reputational value among people who are not working in your professional subfield. Cost wise, they are similar to big national conferences, but they

are sometimes held in smaller cities where hotel rooms and meals are a bit cheaper.

Workshops and Symposia

There are many small gatherings that have a much stronger adherence to a theme or a much narrower focus. These gatherings take the label workshop or symposium to reflect their smaller size. A symposium is like a small conference in that it is organized around a series of panels. However, there is often just one panel at a time and members of the public are usually part of the audience. Workshops are usually closed-door affairs where a group of scholars take turns presenting until everyone in the group has shared their work. Presentation times and discussion periods are typically much longer than in a conference panel and may be complemented by group dialogue on the workshop topic.

Sometimes these are one-off events, convened around a particular topic as part of a grant obtained by the organizers. Sometimes they are recurring. For instance, at the time of this writing, the University of Washington organizes an annual Graduate Workshop on Environmental Politics and the Lemon Project at the College of William and Mary hosts an annual symposium on the legacy of slavery.

The virtue of these events is their tight focus. You can expect high-quality feedback, a highly interested audience, and valuable networking. There are also other benefits. Presenters may speak for longer than at a regular conference and have a longer period for questions and answers. Meals may be arranged and paid for by the workshop organizers so that the scholarly exchange can continue after-hours. The likelihood of having your attendance subsidized or fully paid for is also much higher. Note that the tighter focus can make it more difficult to have your paper accepted; if you are unsure if your work fits, you can email the organizer your topic or title and a short summary and ask if your work seems suitable.

I particularly encourage you to apply to any workshops you find related to your dissertation topic. They can be challenging events because your work will be fully dissected, and you may be expected to read and comment in detail on others' work. However, the richness of the feedback and networking is entirely worth it. Do not assume that such events are reserved for senior scholars either. Often organizers have a commitment to incorporating scholars from across the ranks – including students, early career, and senior scholars – in order to promote cross-pollination and challenge stagnant thinking. The

only real downside, besides opening yourself up for intensive critique of your work, is that such workshops may have lower reputation benefits if they are less well-known or are one-time events.

Scam Conferences

Scam conferences are assembled by organizations and businesses that profit from conference organizing. On their face, these conferences may appear interesting and highly topical, with professional websites and attractive locations. Beneath the surface, however, they are high-priced events that are rarely linked to a reputable university or professional association.

These conferences often prey on the pride or ignorance of the unsuspecting. Once you have developed any sort of digital identity as a researcher, even from just a single conference presentation, scam conference organizers will find your email address and send you an invitation to share about your research at their event. It can be flattering, until you realize it is automated spam. Other, more subtle organizations set up websites that look just like legitimate conference events and, without careful digging, they may trick you into believing that they are legitimate.

Scam conferences also cater to the needs or desires of less scrupulous researchers. One of the hallmarks of a scam conference is the promise that your conference paper will be published in the conference proceedings or an association journal. Often there are the paradoxical promises that papers will both be peer-reviewed (suggesting a screening process) and guaranteed publication. They may indicate that paying your conference fee ensures that your proposal will be accepted (at legitimate conferences this process is competitive). For some academics facing a tenure or promotion review, the promise of a guaranteed presentation and publication on their CV may lure them to a disreputable conference. They are not tricked; they are getting what they paid for.

Some researchers also treat conferences as an opportunity to go on a paid vacation. They have no intention of attending the conference beyond the one presentation they have committed to give. In this case, guaranteed acceptance at a conference located in an interesting location can be very appealing. The high cost is irrelevant if their university is paying for it.

Scam conferences have no value for you. You have no guarantee that the other attendees will really know anything about your topic. There may not even be an audience for your panel if everyone else is off sightseeing or swimming at the beach. The cost is high. In the worst-case scenario, an

important piece of your work will end up published in a journal or proceedings no one has heard of or respects, and you will lose any chance to publish it in a more legitimate venue.

To avoid such conferences, look for these red flags:

- Unusually high conference fee. Use the major conference in your field as a baseline. Scam conferences may have fees double this amount and a very limited discount for graduate students.
- Lack of any link to programs from previous conferences even though the conference claims to be an annual event.
- Promise or implication that all papers will be published in a proceedings or special issue of a journal, particularly a journal you cannot find or that does not seem to be prominent in your field.
- Doing a web search for the conference organizer reveals that they run many conferences on a broad range of topics.
- Organizers are based outside the country or region where the conference is being held (e.g., an organizer from Bulgaria hosting a conference in Singapore or Montreal).

Just one of these flags is not necessarily disqualifying. Sometimes a conference will have a higher-than-average fee because meals are included in the conference cost or because the organizers are subsidizing the attendance of scholars from low-income countries. Sometimes a small workshop will be convened with the intention of developing an edited volume or a special issue of a journal (although the organizers will not promise publication, since that depends on acceptance by the publisher or journal). Sometimes legitimate organizations will host a conference far from their base to try to make it easier for far-flung members to attend. But if you see more than one of these red flags, you should avoid the conference.

Keeping Track

As with many things in your PhD, it is helpful if you can plan your conference attendance in a strategic and systematic way. I suggest that you keep a spreadsheet of conference opportunities and update it regularly as calls for proposals appear in your inbox and through monthly reviews of the best conference aggregators you find in your field. Your spreadsheet could look something like Table 7.1.

Table 7.1 Sample Headers for Conference-Tracking Spreadsheet

Proposal Due Date	*Conference Name*	*Website URL*	*Conference Dates*	*Location/ Registration Cost*	*Sections/ Tracks to Submit to*	*Send Proposal? (Y/N)*	*Date Submitted*	*Date of Expected Response*	*Title of Proposal*	*Notes*

A spreadsheet like this will help you capture and compare the opportunities you come across and track the deadlines for submitting your proposals. Knowing when to expect a response (an approximate date is usually on the conference website) will let you know when you should send a follow-up inquiry or assume a rejection. Notes can include your ideas for how to link your proposal to the conference focus or theme (this can be especially important for workshops and symposia) or any special opportunities you want to take advantage of, like professional development events. You may also want to check the conference website for any information on graduate student funding and add a column noting when funding applications are due. Oddly, you may have to apply for funding or a conference fee waiver before you know if your proposal has been accepted.

EXERCISE 7.3: SELECTING WHERE TO SUBMIT

1. Using the resources from Exercise 7.2, build a spreadsheet and fill it in with six or more conferences, workshops, or symposia suitable for your planned work.
2. Reflect on the following:
   a. Which events are most interesting to you? Why?
   b. Which events will give you the best feedback?
   c. Which events are most likely to be recognized by future employers?
   d. How many events do you have time and funds to attend?
3. Use your answers to #2 to highlight those conferences that are your highest priority for submission.

Writing an Abstract

Relatively few conferences require that you submit a complete paper to apply to attend. The vast majority require that you submit a proposal, which consists primarily of a title and abstract for your planned paper (Baker 2017). Thus, the key to successfully applying to conferences is knowing how to write a good abstract.

More than just a summary, an abstract is a microcosm of your work that allows the reader to assess, in just a minute or two, whether you are

asking an interesting question, using robust methods, and have interesting findings. Put another way, an abstract makes an implicit argument for why your work is important to the profession and needs to be presented publicly.

The main pieces of a good abstract are as follows:

1) The conventional wisdom. This is a summary of existing research or thinking on your topic.
2) Problematization. Here you identify the problem, limitation, or debate within the existing research that suggests a need for new research.
3) The research question. This is a concise statement of the question you intend to answer in order to address the problem identified in the literature.
4) Research design and methods. Here you tell the audience how your research develops an answer to your research question.
5) Findings. You explain what you found (or expect to find).
6) Significance. You relate your findings back to the literature or to real-world problems. "These findings suggest that literature on [topic] must change/adapt/reconsider…" Or "These findings indicate that the best solutions to [problem] involve…"

Here is an example adapted from a conference proposal I coauthored with Cortney Stewart. The numbers in brackets show how the abstract matches the steps given above:

> *[1] Existing scholarship shows that international donors reducing foreign aid to a country frequently seek to devolve responsibility for funding local NGOs to the national government. [2] However, the outcomes of this transition vary widely between contexts; some funding transitions result in a successful government-NGO relationship while others result in an antagonistic relationship. Scholarship on aid reduction has yet to explain this variation. [3] In this paper, we ask, "What factors explain a government's willingness or unwillingness to fund local NGOs during aid reduction?" [4] To answer this question, we generate hypotheses using NGO-government relations theory and test them using case study data from the HIV/AIDS sectors in Thailand and Vietnam. [5] We find that NGO-government relations theory provides a convincing explanation for the outcomes of the sector's transition. The theory indicates that for transition to be successful,*

the NGO-government relationship must shift from a supplementary one, marked by outside funding for NGOs, guarded attitudes, and restrictive government oversight, to a complementary relationship marked by government funding, collaborative attitudes, and regulations that facilitate NGO activities. [6] These findings suggest that donors need to pay attention to the underlying attitudes of NGOs and government, in addition to laws and bureaucratic procedures, when planning funding transitions.

This structure also works for a review piece, although a discussion of methods, findings, and significance may look slightly different. Instead of drawing on empirical data, the methods develop a theoretical framework that is used to analyze the literature. The findings are the results of that analysis, and the significance section can be used to justify a future research agenda. If the abstract above were adapted for a review piece, it might look something like what is written below. Note that in addition to changing steps 4–6, I have also revised the research question since the goal of the paper is now to set up empirical research, rather than report on it.

[1] Existing scholarship shows that international donors reducing foreign aid to a country frequently seek to devolve responsibility for funding local NGOs to the national government. [2] However, the outcomes of this transition vary widely between contexts; some funding transitions result in a successful government-NGO relationship while others result in an antagonistic relationship. Scholarship on aid reduction has yet to explain this variation. [3] In this paper, we ask, "What factors may predict a government's willingness or unwillingness to fund local NGOs during aid reduction?" [4] We answer this question by drawing together the literature on NGO-donor relationships and NGO-government relations. [5] We find that while scholarship on NGO-donor relations stresses donors' desire to maintain control over NGO activities and manage NGO contracts to achieve donor goals, research on NGO-government relations reveals that some actors within local and national governments may embrace NGOs as partners and allies when NGOs' interests align with their own. These findings suggest that local governments may be willing to fund NGOs during aid reduction when either (a) the government believes it can constrain local NGOs to pursue government objectives or (b) key actors within government view NGOs as sharing their agendas. [6] Further research is needed to test the accuracy of these predictions.

EXERCISE 7.4: A BASIC ABSTRACT

Using one of your ideas from Exercise 7.1, complete the following statements to produce a basic abstract:

1. "Existing research on [topic] argues/claims…"
2. "However, [new data/theory/analysis] indicates/reveals…"
3. "To address this problem/limitation/debate, this paper asks: [research question]"
4. "This paper answers this question using a [research design or data source]" OR "This paper answers this question using an analysis of the literature on…"
5. "These [data/analyses] indicate…[findings]"
6. "These findings suggest that literature on [topic] must [change/adapt/reconsider]…" OR "These findings indicate that the best solutions to [problem] involve…" OR "These findings suggest that future research should…"

Note that the maximum length of the abstract will vary depending on the call for papers. It can be as little as 100 words or as much as 1000; 200–300 words is very common. You may not exceed the stated length, but you also should not be too far under it. A call asking for a 700-word abstract is looking for a high degree of detail; submitting a 200-word version probably will not satisfy the reviewers. Pay attention too to any requests for sources. Abstracts typically do not include citations, but some calls – typically those requesting longer abstracts – require them. If that is the case, read the call carefully to find out if the citations are included in the word count for the abstract.

Once your abstract is written, make multiple passes at revising it. Distilling your work down into such a concise form is tricky, and an abstract that seems perfect when you finally finish it may seem incomprehensible when you review it later. When I was a doctoral student, I would allocate a full day to writing an abstract for a conference. Even now, I typically devote an hour or more to writing an abstract, put it aside, and then devote an hour or two to revising it the next day.

Finally, while the abstract is the core of your conference proposal, recognize that some other information may be required. You will need a title for your paper, which may also be subject to a word length. Some conferences will request that you list three to six "keywords": single words or two- or three-word phrases (e.g., government spending or injection drug use) that will help other scholars index or categorize your work. The application system will

also probably ask for some identifying information. The application software may be clunky, and there may be requests for information you did not expect. Complete your abstract and start submitting your application with enough lead time (at least 24 hours before proposals are due) to deal with any problems.

Final Thoughts

Presenting at conferences has many benefits. To improve your research, build your network, and prime the article-writing process, it is good to begin attending conferences early in your studies. Do not worry if you struggle to navigate the application process or if your work feels imperfect. Many conferences have relatively high acceptance rates. Especially for major conferences, one of the main goals is to facilitate dialogue and connections among scholars. Most scholars cannot get funding from their institutions to attend conferences at which they are not presenting, so making the admissions process too selective would undermine this community-building goal. The application materials being evaluated – mostly a short abstract – are also limited, and reviewers may be inclined to give applicants the benefit of the doubt. Lastly, conferences are places to hone work in progress. Therefore, do not worry too much about perfecting your ideas or finalizing your outputs. Find a couple of conferences that seem promising and submit your applications. In the next chapter, we will discuss what to do once a proposal is accepted.

Recommended Readings

Baker, C. (2017). How to write a conference abstract: A five-part plan for pitching your research at almost anything. Available at: https://bakercatherine.wordpress.com/2017/03/15/how-to-write-a-conference-abstract-a-five-part-plan-for-pitching-your-research-at-almost-anything/.

Bassey, A. (n.d.). 7 Reasons why every PhD student should attend academic conferences. Available at: https://authorservices.taylorandfrancis.com/phd-conferences/.

Additional Resources

Cooper, C. A. (2008). Reassessing conference goals and outcomes: A defense of presenting similar papers at multiple conferences. *PS: Political Science & Politics*, *41*(2), 293–295.

Dometrius, N. C. (2008). Academic double-dipping: Professional profit or loss? *PS: Political Science & Politics*, *41*(2), 289–292.

Gupta, D., & Waismel-Manor, I. (2006). Network in progress: A conference primer for graduate students. *PS: Political Science & Politics*, *39*(3), 485–490.